

Skills

Applying Topical Medications

Checklist

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S = Satisfactory U = Unsatisfactory NP = Not Performed

Step	S	U	NP	Comments
Verified the health care provider's orders and compared it with the MAR twice.	☐	☐	☐	
Gathered the necessary equipment and supplies.	☐	☐	☐	
Performed hand hygiene.	☐	☐	☐	
Introduced self to the patient and family.	☐	☐	☐	
Provided for the patient's privacy.	☐	☐	☐	
Identified the patient using two identifiers. Used a bar code system or compared these identifiers with the information on the patient's identification bracelet.	☐	☐	☐	
Explained the procedure to the patient and ensured that he or she agreed to treatment.	☐	☐	☐	
Verified the patient's allergies and checked the expiration date of the medication.	☐	☐	☐	
Took the medication to the patient at the correct time. Gave time-critical medications at the precise time ordered. Applied the six rights of medication administration.	☐	☐	☐	
Labeled all medications, medication containers, and other solutions. The only exceptions are medications that are still in their original container or medications that are administered immediately by the person who prepared them.	☐	☐	☐	
Applied clean gloves. Used sterile gloves if the patient had any open skin areas.	☐	☐	☐	
Helped the patient into a comfortable position.	☐	☐	☐	

Discussed the purpose of each medication, its action, and possible adverse effects. Allowed the patient to ask questions.



Applied topical creams, ointments, and oil-based lotions:



1. Exposed the affected area while keeping unaffected areas covered.
2. Washed, rinsed, and dried the affected area before applying medication.
3. For excessively dry or flaking skin, applied the topical agent while skin was still damp.
4. Removed gloves, performed hand hygiene, and applied new clean gloves.
5. Placed the required amount of medication in the palm and warmed it by rubbing it briskly between the hands. Spread the medication evenly over the patient's skin using long strokes in the direction of hair growth.
6. Did not vigorously rub the skin. Applied to the thickness specified by the manufacturer's instructions.
7. Explained to patient that skin may feel greasy after application.

Applying a transdermal patch:



1. Applied clean gloves and removed the old patch, and cleansed area with soap and water.
2. Folded the sticky sides of the patch together and disposed according to agency policy.
3. Used a felt-tip marker to note the date, time, and initials of the person applying the new patch.
4. Applied clean gloves.
5. Applied new patch to a clean, dry area, avoiding the previous site for at least a week.
6. Carefully removed the plastic liner of the new patch by holding the patch around the edges.
7. Applied the patch immediately to the selected site. Pressed around the edges of the patch with one or two fingers to ensure that the patch adhered well. Applied an overlay if one is provided with the patch.
8. Removed gloves and performed hand hygiene.

Administering aerosol sprays:



1. When the area of application was near the face, asked the patient to turn his or her face away from the spray or briefly covered the face with a towel.
2. Shook the container vigorously. Read the container label for the recommended distance at which to hold the spray away from the area.
3. Sprayed the medication evenly over the affected site.

Applied a suspension-based lotion:



1. Put on clean gloves. Shook the container vigorously.
2. Applied a small amount of lotion to a small gauze dressing or pad, and applied it to the skin. Dabbed the affected area and avoided rubbing vigorously.
3. Explained to the patient that the area would feel cool and dry.

Applied a powder:



1. Made sure skin surface was thoroughly dry. Fully spread apart any skin folds and dried with a towel.

2. When the area of application was near the face, asked the patient to turn his or her face away from the powder or briefly covered the face with a towel.
3. Dusted the skin site with a dispenser so that the area was covered with a thin layer of powder.

Disposed of soiled supplies in the appropriate trash receptacle, removed and disposed of gloves, and performed hand hygiene.

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Helped the patient into a comfortable position, and placed toiletries and personal items within reach.

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Placed the call light within easy reach, and made sure the patient knew how to use it to summon assistance.

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Raised the appropriate number of side rails and lowered the bed to the lowest position.

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Left the patient's room tidy.

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Documented and reported the patient's response and expected or unexpected outcomes.

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Learner: _____
Evaluator: _____
Date: _____

Signature: _____
Signature: _____